



WATCH RAPID FIRE
WITH SAI KISHORE

« Standard of playing spin without risk has come down in domestic cricket »

SAI KISHORE

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Sai Kishore walked in wearing a breezy, washed-print shirt that mirrored the balance he brings to the field — relaxed yet purposeful. Over the past few months, the left-arm finger-spinner has juggled roles with the same calm authority: leading IDream Tiruppur Tamizhans to its maiden Tamil Nadu Premier League (TNPL) crown, playing every game for Gujarat Titans in the Indian Premier League (IPL), and sharpening his red-ball craft with Surrey, where an 11-wicket haul across two matches underlined his pedigree. Now, as he recovers from an injury that has sidelined him from the Buchi Babu tournament, the Tamil Nadu captain sits down with *Sportstar* to discuss leadership, workload, evolving skills, and his team's Ranji Trophy ambitions.

You've played across three T20 ecosystems — IPL, Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (SMAT), and TNPL. How does your mindset shift between them, and how much of it is skill versus psychology?

When you go to the IPL, all your senses switch on. There's a lot at stake because one good season can secure your career. In Mushtaq Ali or TNPL, the standard of cricket isn't very different, but the mindset is. You can't take it lightly — you still need the same seriousness while bowling. For me, it's largely psychological, treating all levels with equal importance. IPL is the one place where the pressure to perform is relentless.

I see it like an artist. Take an A. R. Rahman concert — whether it's in Wembley, Chennai, or Mumbai, the quality has to remain the same. That's how I view my game: pure and

true to myself, regardless of where I play.

In TNPL you play against familiar faces, while in IPL it's world-class opponents. Does that make TNPL easier or tougher because they know you well?

Skill-wise, IPL is tougher. But psychologically, TNPL can be more challenging. Complacency creeps in — you feel you've played the IPL and now you're back. Maintaining the same focus becomes the real test. In IPL, you're naturally driven; it's the event you prepare for all year. The challenge is to switch on with the same intensity for every other tournament.

Did you personally struggle with that switch when you first returned to TNPL after IPL?

Not really. I never had a